Investing in skilling them for contemporary times is now being paralleled by endeavours to promote Indian talent through start-ups and innovation. These are not just economic or even social initiatives but strategic steps laden with deep meaning for international relations. Let us not forget that one important driver of the transformed India–US relationship was the H1B visa flow. Addressing the rising aspirations of people at home and realizing ambitions abroad are but two sides of the same coin.

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While the manner of engaging the world may be more considered, its effectiveness will really be judged by how the world views us now. It is, therefore, worthwhile to reflect on the changing external perceptions of India. Much of this centres on the nation's economic and technological progress. We were seen as the global back office for many years, but India has now surged well past that limited image. The knowledge economy has increasingly made us the crucial technology partner for many economies. The talk has now shifted to collaboration in complex fields like defence manufacturing and semiconductors. Our infrastructure improvements, coupled with making it easier to do business, have propelled us to become the largest destination for foreign direct investment (FDI). The Covid experience established us as the pharmacy of the world. That India handled the Covid well is widely recognized, but it is the economic bounce-back that is seen as the more consequential happening.

A lot of the India story discussed abroad revolves around improved governance. A digital delivery on such an enormous scale has been a particular source of fascination. Progress on the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG) front magnifies the sense of a society on the move. The mosaic is made up of many granules, from vaccines and health industry to 5G stack and space launches, or indeed, to educational branding or Make in India outcomes. The G20 presidency has also served to acquaint a wide cross-section of policymakers and influencers with infrastructure improvement and governance progress. This emphasis on delivery has led to more effective implementation of project commitments abroad. That great care is taken to synchronize budgeting is only proof again of how